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Festive tempo
Tirupananthal Viswanathan and Vijayalakshmi with A.V. Selvam and Tiruvenkadu T.M. Guhan on the thavil.
PHOTO: K. PICHUMANI

Resonance of the reed

Practice and partnership lay at the core of the Nadotsavam festival, which turned the spotlight on the instrument

Aishwarya Raghunathan

The nagaswaram occupies a position of eminence among aerophone musical instruments of South India. A double-reed instrument, it is classified among the mangala vadyams, whose presence is mandatory at temple rituals and auspicious ceremonies.

It was this tradition that the third edition of Nadotsavam sought to celebrate, presenting six concerts across three days at The Music Academy, offering sustained engagement with the nagaswaram-thavil partnership.

The festival's inaugural concert featured artiste-couple Tirupananthal Viswanathan and Vijayalakshmi. They were accompanied by Achalpuram A.V. Selvam and Tiruvenkadu T.M. Guhan on the thavil. The four musicians brought to the occasion their sustained training and familiarity with the tradition's demands.

The concert opened with Tyagaraja's 'Sri ganapati sevimpara' in Sowrashtram, a fitting invocation that the instrument carried with characteristic fullness. The thavil accompaniment was notable for its structured division: Selvam held the pallavi, Guhan stepped in for the anupallavi, and Selvam returned for the charanam – an arrangement that lent the piece a conversational rhythm between the two percussionists. What further distinguished the evening was the manner in which the thavil artistes kept up the momentum with their interludes. The contrast in their approach was interesting. While Selvam's playing carried a tonal resonance that filled the hall, Guhan's greater use of the thoppi lent a textural subtlety that balanced the ensemble well.

An alapana in Nasikabhushani preceded 'Mara vairi' followed by the

brisk 'Nati mata marachitvo' by Tyagaraja in Devakriya, a kriti that demands not only speed but also rhythmic steadiness. Here, Guhan's accompaniment was particularly assured, the kalapramanam held without drift from first beat to the last.

The concert deepened considerably as Viswanathan moved to an unhurried and naadam-rich Pantuvarali alapana, that drew the audience's attention through every phrase.

The alapana for Muthu Thandavar's 'Eesane koti surya' captured the raga's inherent flavour. The duo rendered the kriti by working across registers – Vijayalakshmi on the lower pitch, Viswanathan on the higher.

Thanjavur Sankara Iyer's 'Natajana palini' in Nalinakanti followed, its alapana a studied contrast to the preceding Pantuvarali – lighter in disposition, the phrases moving with a certain ease.

'Appan avatharitha' in Karaharapriya was the evening's centrepiece – Viswanathan's alapana assured, the kalpanaswaras well-rounded. A brief swarastanam lapse from Vijayalakshmi was steadied unobtrusively by Viswanathan. The thani opened with a five-avartanam interplay, with tistra nadai from Selvam standing out for soltu clarity. Guhan's thoppi double strokes, gumki technique and rim shot were the highlights. The kuraippu reduced to a single beat before a clean, if somewhat self-contained, 84-beat mohara korvai closed the thani to a warm audience response.

The concert drew to a close through three well-chosen pieces – Manikkavachagar's 'Ammaye appa' in Mohanam, followed by Thirugnanasambandar's 'Manthiramavathu' in Navroj and Arunagirinathar's Tiruppugazh verse in Husseni. The final moments were both about bhakti and musical substance.



Musical allies
Pazhayaseevaram G. Kalidass and Koleri Vinoth Kumar.
PHOTO: K. PICHUMANI

Aishwarya Raghunathan

The final day's concert of the festival featured Pazhayaseevaram G. Kalidass and Koleri G. Vinoth Kumar. It opened in the manner of a traditional concert – a varnam in Charukesi, 'Innum en manam', with Tirukkadayur T.G. Babu on the thavil through the muktayi swara before Panapakkam Tamizhselvan took over.

The nagaswaram playing was notable for its dynamic range – mellow where the phrase demanded, bold where it needed to be. Mazhavai Chidambara Bharati's 'Pahi pahi balaganapathi' in Hamsadhwani followed by kalpanaswaras, the thavil accompaniment sitting in natural alignment with the nagaswaram throughout.

Kalidass' alapana in Anandabhairavi preceded 'Kamalamba samrakshatu

maam', one of the Muthuswami Dikshitar's Kamalamba Navaavarana kritis. It was rendered to mark the composer's 250th birth anniversary. Played in the keezh kaalam, the piece demanded and received precise thavil accompaniment; the kala pramanam held steadily throughout. Vinoth's continuous shadjam resonance worked quietly, grounding the ensemble and deepening the overall tonal effect.

Tyagaraja's 'Neevada ne gana' in Saranga followed. The raga's brighter disposition came in the shift to the mel kalam, offering an effective contrast to Anandabhairavi's meditateness.

The main piece of the evening was in Purvikalyani and the kriti chosen was Dikshitar's 'Meenakshi memudham' – Kalidass' alapana unfolding with phrases that Vinoth followed with impressive attentiveness, repeating each with reasonable sangati clarity. The occasional

lapse in swarasthanam accuracy from Vinoth notwithstanding, the exchange had an organic quality that served the raga well. In the kalpanaswaras segment, Babu accompanied Kalidass and Tamizhselvan played for Vinoth.

The thani was anchored by a good use of karvais and a measured kuraippu in the lower octave, building steadily to an effective close.

The mohara korvai that followed carried well-constructed soltu development, Babu's contribution holding its own through the more complex passages – a thani that, taken as a whole, had its moments of genuine engagement.

Lalgudi Jayaraman's thillana in Misra Sivaranjani stood out for its rhythmic buoyancy and was followed by 'Eru mayil eri', a ragamalika that seamlessly wove together Bageshri, Hamsanandi, Atana and Surutti.

In tune with tradition

Pilot-turned-araiyar Bharathwajan on keeping alive the hereditary practice that blends literature, music and theatre

Suganthy Krishnamachari

Araiyaar Sevai is a ritual that has sustained for over a millennium. It is traditionally performed by hereditary male Araiyaars, who sing and enact the Divya Prabandham verses as a divine offering. Today, quite a few young araiyaars are professionally qualified, yet remain committed to preserving this tradition.

One such practitioner is Bharathwajan Araiyaar, a pilot with a passion for Araiyaar Sevai. Listening to him at a lecture, a few months ago, at the Department of Vaishnavism, University of Madras, you realised how deeply he is rooted in the practice. He spoke of the ritual's rich temple heritage

and its seamless integration of all three aspects of Muthamizh – *iyal* (literature), *isai* (music) and *natakam* (theatre).

The practice of reciting the pasurams in front of Lord Ranganatha of Srirangam was begun by Thirumangai Azhwar. However, over time, the Divya Prabandham verses were lost. It was the Vaishnava acharya Nathamuni (mid ninth to mid 10th century CE) who retrieved and arranged for them to be presented with music and theatrical elements. Bharathwajan said that the music that Nathamuni created for the pasurams is reverentially referred to as *deva gaanam* (divine music).

To illustrate the musical acumen of Nathamuni, Bharathwajan highlighted an episode during a conversation after the lecture. Once, when



Upholding a legacy Bharathwajan Araiyaar (in red headgear) performing Araiyaar Sevai. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Nathamuni was asked to establish the superiority of this *deva gaanam* over ordinary forms of music, he requested the king to arrange for the playing of 4,000 cymbals, all at once. Just by listening to their tonal quality, Nathamuni was able to identify the metals used to make the cymbals, their proportion and the exact weight of each cymbal. The king acknowledged Nathamuni's knowledge of music and the superiority of

his *deva gaanam*.

According to Bharathwajan, Nathamuni drew from many ragas of the Sama Veda to come up with music for the Divya Prabandham. Demonstrating the *min uruvai* verse of *Thirunedunthandagam*, Bharathwajan highlighted the similarity between Nathamuni's music composition and melodic structure of the Sama Veda. "Nathamuni's music captures the emotions and philosophy

underlying each verse in the Divya Prabandham," he said.

While talking about the Tiruppavai renditions, he explained how the verses are presented in different ways by araiyaars. When Ranganatha is visualised as a king presiding over his court, the verses are sung only in arohanam. When he is imagined as a child, it is rendered in a coaxing tone.

Before the *adhyayana utsavam* begins in Srirangam, the araiyaars are escorted from

their house to the temple, accompanied by the playing of ekkalam, an ancient wind instrument, still used in the temple. The street where the araiyaars reside in Srirangam was once called *Sentamizh Paaduvaa Veedhi* (the street where those who sing beautiful Tamil verses reside), emphasising the importance given to the musical presentation of the pasurams.

When the music can convey so much, what is the need for abhinaya? "What if there are aurally-challenged people? The idea is to ensure that the meaning of the verses reaches everyone. There were temple dancers even before Nathamuni's time, and he incorporated their abhinaya to explain the verses. While many hymns once included abhinaya, only a few retain it today," he shared.

Thambiranpadi Vyakhyanam is a commentary written by an araiyaar. Presented in prose style, it helps araiyaars dramatise the events described in the verses. "*Thambiranpadi* is the oldest commentary, written around the period of Nathamuni. Another araiyaar called Deivasigamani wrote *Kondattangal* verses, which are also presented by araiyaars," said Bharathwajan. *Kondattangal* verses, which capture the flavours of

different festivals, are set in different metres. Some of them are difficult, and when Bharathwajan recites, it is obvious that a few are tongue twisters.

When did he get interested in Araiyaar Sevai? "When I was three, I first began to sing, using a pair of cymbals. But formal training began when I was six. By nine, I had presented all the verses of Thondaradippodi Azhwar's *Thirumaalai*."

"Araiyaar sevai was never stopped, even after the sack of Srirangam in the 14th century, when the processional deity was taken away from the town for 48 years," said Bharathwajan. Everyone associated with the temple had left the town, but Araiyaar Sevai continued. Afraid of attracting the attention of enemies, araiyaars then kept time with their hands instead of cymbals.

Bharathwajan hails from a family that gives equal importance to tradition and education. His father Lakshminarayanan, was a rank holder in Electrical Engineering from REC Trichy (now NIT), and worked for BHEL. But he never once missed Araiyaar Sevai. Neither has Bharathwajan. Now, his seven-year-old son Aparajithan has begun training in the ritual.

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THE HINDU

Songs that continue to echo
How T.M. Soundararajan's popular numbers powered a political movement **p2**

Rhythmic spark
Akkarai Sisters' concert had a surprise element – Sornalatha's konnakol **p3**



A NEW PLAY THAT DELVES INTO QUEER HISTORY

Mahesh Dattani's *The Monk and The Warrior* is an unusual love story **p4**

Rachel Rhine

Augustine Paul's presence in the Western classical music circles of Chennai has long been less an event and more a constant. His name appears in choir lists, concert brochures and music conversations with equal familiarity, carried across generations of singers who learnt their first scales, first blends and first rehearsal discipline under his direction. Over the years, his work has earned wide recognition, including a Fellowship FRSL (Hons) from The Rock School of Music, the Lifetime Achievement Award 2024 from the Stop-Gaps Cultural Academy in Mumbai, and honours from the Kuwait Chamber Chorale and Ahmadi Music Group.

"It is encouraging when awards come for Western classical music in India, where not many follow and practise it. These awards inspire me to create more music. They will also motivate my fellow musicians to strive for greater heights," says Augustine, the music director of the Madras Musical Association Choir, which was founded in 1893.

Augustine's music journey began with the Palayamkottai Cathedral choir. He then joined a teenage rock band, driven by his curiosity for instruments ranging from the organ and violin to the mandolin and guitar. Music, at that stage, was less a path than an environment. Moving to Chennai brought a different kind of listening – structured choral singing, regular rehearsals and exposure to disciplined ensemble sound – that gradually shaped his instincts.

Call of the baton Teacher and conductor Augustine Paul with the MMA Symphony Orchestra at Chennai's Musuem Theatre. PHOTOS: M. VEDAN AND B. VELANKANNI RAJ



The choral frontman

Ahead of presenting an Easter repertoire, Augustine Paul reflects on how the fusion of Indian melodies and Western harmony have found a lasting meeting point in choirs

Working with the Emmanuel Methodist Church choir and the Male Voice Ensemble deepened his interest in arrangement. Studio sessions with professional musicians added technical experience, while singing with groups such as the Minstrels, Madrigals and Camerata introduced him to early music traditions and ensemble precision. These eventually led him to form The Octet Cantabile in 1994. Then came 'The Chromatics', with its focus on opera repertoire and Augustine's long stewardship of the Madras Musical Association choir.

For nearly two decades, however, music ran parallelly to a bank job. "I think it was divine providence that I chose music as a career. I enjoyed teaching and performing. I was fortunate to have had talented and hard working students and dedicated musicians to sing with. I also got to conduct and lead musically rich choirs," he shares.

Teaching became central to Augustine's work. Many of Chennai's younger conductors count him among their

half of Augustine's life, ensemble-building shaped the other. "Choirs and ensembles are two different things. Success of a choir depends on administration, choice of repertoire, rehearsals, having a set of good musicians constantly for years and to an extent your own disposition and musicianship. Any choir will have to face the issue of a floating population. One should not complain about people moving out as long as there new ones joining. But working with an ensemble involves more responsibilities. As a leader, you have to win the confidence and respect of all members and strive to keep the group together. People skills are needed as much as musicianship to get the group to work together. You need a strong mind to take the highs and lows of an ensemble," shares Augustine.

International tours with the MMA Choir have placed Indian singers alongside large festival choirs abroad. "There are two kinds of international concerts – one for audiences of Indian origin and the other for native audiences in different countries. At music festivals, we often become part of large choirs of 300 to 400 voices drawn from across the globe. It's easier to connect with NRIs because we share a common cultural base. But when we performed with European choirs, they responded warmly and admired our strength in Western music, even though it is not native to us. We have performed many standard classical repertoires abroad and have been warmly applauded by international audiences."

Chennai's Western choral tradition forms the backdrop to much of Augustine's work. He points out that the city's engagement with Western classical music stretches back over a century. According to him, Western music has been present in Chennai for at least 150

years. "The number of choirs, within churches and outside, which function throughout the year represents a tradition that has few equals in the country."

One of Augustine's more quietly influential interventions has been the harmonisation of Tamil Christian keerthanais. "I come from a church tradition where hymns are sung in harmony, while keerthanais are traditionally not sung that way. But when I tried presenting a medley of keerthanais at the first Octet concert, we received rave reviews." Audience appreciation prompted the release of two CDs of keerthanais. It also encouraged him to explore new works such as Bilahari, Vande Mataram, Jana Gana Mana and more recently, Dingiri Dingale, arranged for symphony orchestras.

The experiments were driven not by manifesto but by listening. "The colour that emerges from Indian melodies combined with Western harmonies is unique," he says. Today, vernacular gospel songs rendered in harmony are commonplace across Tamil Nadu and Kerala. "Every gospel choir and ensemble now sings in harmony. They may not even realise that what they are doing is a fusion of Indian tunes and Western harmony." What once seemed experimental has, quietly, become the norm.

Augustine's progression from singer to conductor also informs his philosophy. Having spent three decades within choirs, before standing in front of them, he emphasises rehearsal technique and shared ownership. A mentor, he believes, must not feel threatened by younger talent. When asked what endures after decades of work, his response: "Be true to yourself. Keep learning new skills and work hard. The world can go on without you, so do your best while you have the chance," he says.

Celebratory notes

Augustine Paul's upcoming concerts include the presentation of *Messa di Gloria* and Easter repertoire at TELC Arulnathar Lutheran Church, Kilpauk, April 4, 6 p.m. — continuing a performance cycle that reflects both tradition and continuity in the city's Western classical calendar.

mentors, but he resists the language of legacy. Instead, he speaks of responsibility. "Respecting your students, giving them space and encouraging them along the way make a good teacher. And so also taking pride in their success."

Watching his students chart their own paths has been a constant in his career. Some moved into film and theatre music, others into performance or pedagogy. "It's a question of adaptation. I teach music and they choose their own careers. When there are musicians with sound musical knowledge, there will be good music too. It gives me immense joy when they remain in music and put what they have learnt into practice. Some acknowledge their teachers in public, when they achieve big. Some keep them in their heart," he says.

If teaching shaped one



CULTUREBRIEFS

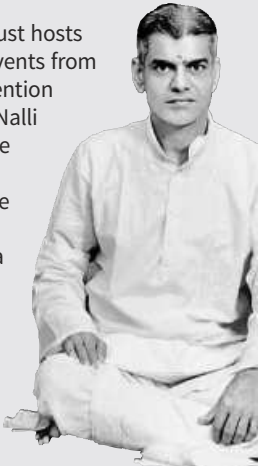
From students, with love

Disciples of the legendary musician and guru Suguna Purushothaman will come together on April 5 to launch a book titled *Navagraha Tamil Keerthanaigal*, composed by her. The kritis propitiate the deities of nine different temples dedicated to nine planets, all located in Tamil Nadu. The book contains a few more Tamil compositions. The event (10.30 a.m.) will take place at The Artery, Balaji Nagar, Royapettah. A pioneering woman vaggeyakara, Suguna Purushothaman has composed 150 songs, predominantly in Tamil. Her wide repertoire includes varnams, kritis, thillanas and ragamalikas.



Dedicated to past masters

Sri Ariyakkudi and Sri K V Narayanaswamy Memorial Trust hosts the 23rd remembrance day events from today to April 5, at R.K. Convention Centre, Mylapore. Art patron Nalli Kuppuswami Chetti will be the chief guest for today's programme, which will feature Anuradha K.N.'s vocal concert at 6.15 p.m. T.S. Pattabhirama Pandit's vocal concert will take place on April 4, 6.15 p.m. The last day (April 5, 10.15 a.m.) will feature a lecture demonstration by voxologist Shyamala Vinod on 'A Detailed and Humble Understanding of the Voice and vocalisation of K.V. Narayanaswamy'. H.S. Prasanth's vocal concert will take place at 6.15 p.m. The students of Padma Narayanaswamy will perform on all days.



Evening of ragas

The Music Academy will feature the following concerts at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall. Details: T.S. Pattabhirama Pandit's Sri Rama Navami concert will take place today at 6 p.m. The programme is organised under the endowment instituted by Madhavi Rajagopalan in memory of R. Seethammal. April 6, 6 p.m.: Gayatri Vibhavari Vyakaranam's vocal concert will take place as part of HCL Concert series. April 8, 6 p.m.: Kamala Deepthi's concert will be themed on Gopalakrishna Bharathi's compositions. The concert is organised under the endowment, instituted by Malathi Rangaswami in memory of Sri. T.T. Rangaswami. April 9, 6 p.m.: E.R. Anirudh's vocal concert will be held under the endowment instituted by K Vivekanandan in memory of his grandfather Semmangudi R Srinivasa Iyer.

Enduring appeal (From left) T.M. Soundararajan; with actor Sivaji Ganesan, former Finance and Defence Minister C. Subramaniam, music directors Viswanathan and Ramamoorthy at the Bharathi Day celebration in Madras in 1961; and at a recording studio. PHOTOS: THE HINDU ARCHIVES & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



K. Jeshi

“His voice was a priceless treasure,” says T. Vijayaraj, an ardent admirer of legendary singer T.M. Soundararajan (TMS). Recalling his association with the singer, whose 103rd birth anniversary fell on March 24, Vijayaraj says that TMS’ songs formed an integral part of the Dravidian political firmament. “Even today, numbers such as ‘Naan aanaiyittal’ and ‘Yaen endra kelvi ketkaamal vaazhkai illai’ echo during election campaigns and rallies across Tamil Nadu. These songs contributed immensely in boosting MGR’s popularity and helped him win a huge fan following.”

Vijayaraj has directed a documentary series *Imayathudan Oru Isai Payanam* on the singer’s journey to stardom. He shot the first episode of the series in Madurai, at TMS’s house in Thaerkku Krishnan Koil Street, the singer’s birthplace. Another episode was filmed at Pakshiraja Studios in Coimbatore, where TMS

recorded ‘Eththanai kaalam thaana emaatruvaar’ for the MGR blockbuster *Malai Kallan*. He also filmed at Bharathiyar Illam in Triplicane, where TMS interacted with the poet’s grandson. Other episodes were filmed at Modern Theatre in Salem, where the singer recorded many songs for actor Jaishankar. The final episode was shot at Adyar Film Institute. “TMS sang

the popular title song ‘Unnai dhinam thaedum thalaivan’ for Vijayakanth in *Uzhavar Magan*, directed by

Aabaavaanan, an alumnus of the institute. In 1989, he sang six songs for actor Sathyaraj in *Thaai Naadu*. The series traces TMS’ rise to stardom, as he became the voice of MGR and Sivaji Ganesan,” shares Vijayaraj, awaiting approval from an OTT platform to air the series. Vijayaraj studied acting at Adyar Film Institute and worked with Tamil Nadu Films Division in the theatre news reel section in the 1990s. It was

then that Vijayaraj realised that there were no visual record of icons such as TMS, Mohammed Rafi, Kannadasan or Bharatiyar. “We remember famous people only after they are gone. I wanted to do something during the lifetime of TMS,” says the man who documented the singer’s journey by revisiting iconic studios along with him between 2001 and 2013. “To mark the birth centenary of TMS in 2023, Chief Minister M.K. Stalin unveiled a bronze life-size statue of the singer at the Madurai Corporation East Zone Office. It was a great honour. Born in Madurai in 1923, TMS sang over 10,000 songs across six generations

spanning more than five decades since 1950.” While TMS’s versatility comes through in songs such as ‘Engay nimmadhi’, ‘Manappara maadukatti’ and ‘Veedu varai uravu’, his mastery in modulation technique, and emotions-laden singing stand out in ‘Satti suddhadadaa’ or the revolutionary ‘Aham enbadhu madamaiaada’ – another MGR song that draws attention to Dravidian ideologies. “His songs for MGR were political statements that elevated his image as a champion of the poor,” says Vijayaraj adding, “The songs still resonate with people, because they hold out hope.”

Vijayaraj recalls some special moments while working on the documentary. “One segment features Lata Mangeshkar sharing about her fan-moment with Sivaji Ganesan with TMS. There are interviews with maestro Ilayaraja (TMS sang ‘Annakili unnai thaeduthu’ for his first film *Annakili*), A.R. Rahman, K.J. Yesudas and actors such as Kamal Hassan and Rajinikanth,” he says, adding that a visit to MGR’s House – Chandranthi Nilayam – at Kuzhalmannam village in Kerala was another memorable outing. He adds, “TMS became emotional there. He shared a special bond with MGR.”



To mark the birth centenary of TMS in 2023, Chief Minister M.K. Stalin unveiled a bronze life-size statue of the singer at the Madurai Corporation East Zone Office.

T. VIJAYARAJ



supernatural curse tied to Sandeepan’s past begins to manifest in the present – suggesting that some truths cannot be contained or exorcised simply by telling them. The play tests the limits of rationality. Vikranth, best known for bringing Disney’s *Beauty and the Beast* to the Indian stage, follows the original’s minimalist two-actor format, clever use of sound, set design, lighting and audience imagination to create the mood and menace without ornate spectacle. Whether it is a train on rails or a pony and trap ride, Vikranth hand-holds us, with the feisty dog – Tara – in tow, into the haunting mystery. The adaptation does not probe the curse nor does it delve deeply into Indian experiences of trauma and silence, and as a result, it misses an opportunity to engage intensely with socio-political, cultural anxieties and beliefs. However, the performances and atmospheric tension remain gripping. Actor Gopal Datt shifts from his familiar screen persona to convey layered trauma, father’s regret and mounting dread. Sandeepan’s scepticism evolves convincingly into fear, creating believable tension. In a two-actor piece, chemistry is everything. The play works because their interactions make the supernatural feel invasive. The meta-layer, where one character directs the other and the ghost tells its story through them, creates a shift in the power dynamics; with humour turning into horror and emotional vulnerability overtaking you. Together, they remind us that the most terrifying experiences are those we stage ourselves.

(Ankahi will be staged on April 18 and 19 at NCPA, Mumbai)



The ghost story

A new Hindi play, *Ankahi*, attempts to explore the supernatural thriller genre in Indian theatre

Anuj Kumar

Those who follow popular culture know that horror’s surge is no accident. It mirrors social and cultural unease, and horror tales thrive in uncertain times by externalising fears. With *Simmers* in theatres and *Khauf* on OTT, Aadyam Theatre opened its eighth season this past week with the premiere of Vikranth Pawar’s *Ankahi* at Kamani Auditorium in New Delhi. Over the course of 90 minutes, one discovers how horror – on stage – is one of the most powerful and perhaps an underrated way to experience fear. Unlike films, where cameras and editing control what you see and artificially build tension, live theatre, when projected well, makes its scares feel immediate and unpredictable. A Hindi adaptation of Susan Hill’s *The Woman in Black*, which was famously adapted for the West End by Stephen Mallatratt, *Ankahi*

unfolds as a meta-psychological thriller, infused with strong supernatural elements. It is the story of Sandeepan Chauhan (Gopal Datt), a middle-aged lawyer burdened by a terrifying secret from his past that he has never been able to voice or escape. Desperate to confront this unspoken (ankahi) truth, he seeks the

help of a young, rational theatre actor played by Rohit Chaudhary, who has also adapted the play. What begins as a collaborative rehearsal, where Sandeepan tries to turn his real-life ordeal into a staged performance, gradually draws both the characters and the audience into his traumatic memories of an encounter with a malevolent spirit. Sandeepan re-enacts a seemingly routine professional assignment – he travels to the misty and marshy Sunderbans to settle the estate of a deceased woman, Fatima Ilyas. As the ‘performance’ progresses, Sandeepan’s recollection reveals a disturbing encounter with a mysterious, gaunt figure. This leads to a tragic tale of loss, unresolved maternal grief and vengeance. The line between memory and reality steadily blurs as the young actor gets deeper into the narrative, while the

Rebels with a cause

Keelaka Dance Company’s ‘Rebel Ranis’, reimagines women from the epics

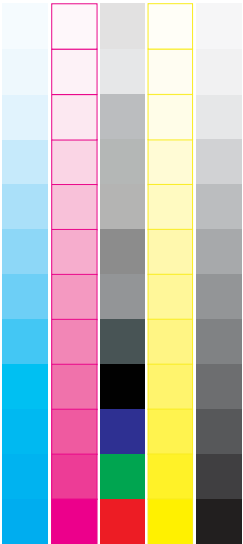


Neha Kirpal

A new bold dance-theatre production – ‘Rebel Ranis’ – that reimagines female narratives from our epics through a contemporary lens, is an initiative of the Delhi-based Keelaka Dance Company. It blends Bharatanatyam with fluid modern movements and jazz-style Tamil tunes. “The production was born from the question: What if our epics were written by women?” shares Aneesha Grover, director, Keelaka Dance Company, who has long been inspired by the layered, unapologetic writing of Eve Ensler’s *The Vagina Monologues* and its focus on lived female experience “without dilution”. It led her to think about the inherited narratives and voices that have shaped our cultural history. “My practice applies an intentional feminine gaze on our ancient literature. *Rebel Ranis* is an attempt to restore complexity, agency and nuance, allowing women to author their own truths,” she adds. The production brings together Kaikeyi, Draupadi,

Karaikal Ammaiyar and Sita – women separated by time, yet bound by their experiences. The work unfolds through Bharatanatyam, contemporary dance, theatre and live Tamil music – creating a layered, visceral language of storytelling. “While Kaikeyi confronts early maternity and the suppression of her political self, Draupadi transforms her trauma of assault into awakening, Karaikal Ammaiyar rejects the body to embrace formless liberation, and Sita rises as Mahakali to redress patriarchal wrongs. Together, they reveal that despite the passage of time, the condition of women has only shifted marginally – demanding a practice of righteous rage to create change,” says Aneesha. According to Jyotsna Shourie, co-director of Keelaka Dance Company, Bharatanatyam today finds itself at the crossroads of tradition and transformation. “The production tries to demystify the stylised classical form while reimagining ancient narratives for a new-age audience.” Talking about the production’s music, Aneesha says it’s a mix of Indian classical, folk and jazz. Keelaka’s dancers take on the

dual role of actors, delivering dialogues in English. The performance site varies from a stage and the black box to museums. “The plan is to make viewers part of the show. We want it interactive to be able to convey what we want and get instant feedback.” Some of Keelaka’s previous works include ‘Sakhi’ a dance theatre that explored a fictional friendship between Sita and Draupadi; ‘Kalatra’ on the dual dimensions of love between Muruga and his consorts Deivanai and Valli; ‘Ullalume’, an adaptation of Edgar Allan Poe’s haunting poem and their first breakthrough from Indian mythology and ‘Echoes of Time’, an immersive and interactive classical dance experience, which had the audience moving from room to room experiencing the four yugas. Keelaka has also collaborated with popular design brands such as Ekaya Benares, Raw Mango, Ogaan and designer Gaurav Gupta as well as platforms such as Design ID and the India Art Fair. Keelaka will soon come up with a production rooted in Tamil poetry, where text, dance and music are in constant dialogue. “We’re drawing from diverse soundscapes and genres while making the musicians active characters within the storyline,” says Aneesha.



Muthuswami Dikshitar's 'Mamava pattabhi rama' in Manirangu was rendered next. The main focus was on the elaborate exposition of Varali, yet another sombre raga, sung with poignant phrases. Tyagaraja's 'Eti janmamidi' was their choice here, and they conveyed well the emotions in it. The niraval at 'Sagara sayanuni' highlighted the raga bhava and the composer's bhakti towards Rama. The swara exchanges were centered on shadjam seaguing into tani avartanam by S. Sundarkumar on the mridangam and S. Karthick on the ghatam.



The concert concluded with Dikshitar's 'Rama rama ramkali' set in raga Ramkali, tinged with a Hindustani flavour, and Papanasam Sivan's 'Ramanai bhajithal' in raga Maund.

Seamless synergy

Akkarai Sisters rendered time-tested kritis with Sornalatha's konnakol adding an unexpected rhythmic spark



Ram Yantra installed at Ayodhya



Under the guidance of Sri Shankara Vijayendra Saraswathi Swamigal, the 70th Acharya of Sri Kanchi Kamakoti Peetam, a 3x3 ft copper based gold-plated Nutana Swarna Ram Yantram has been installed in the second storey above the garbha griha at Rama Mandir in Ayodhya, on the occasion of Sri Rama Navami. Modelled on the ancient Sri Rama Yantra of the Upanishad Math in Kanchipuram, the new Yantram, has mantras in Devanagari script. The Yantram in Upanishad Math, made of Salagrama stone, features select mantras representing various aspects and avatars of Vishnu, carved in old Grantha script and embedded with various Bijakshara mantras. At its core lies the Sri Rama mantra with the Bijakshara of Sita Devi, and is layered with other shlokas such as the Rama Gayatri Mantra. The Rama Yantra is again embedded with other Bijaksharas in the Shatkona design. Additional rings contain Akshara, Vasudeva, Sudarshana and Narasimha mantras, all set within Padma Dalams. Surrounding these mantras, the word Vashat is inscribed 86 times. This was handed over by the 70th Shankaracharya of Kanchi Math to the Ram Mandir in November 2024 for Dashavathara pujas.



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The logo for Fedha by CHALLANI. It features the word "Fedha" in a large, dark teal serif font. Above the letter "a" is a stylized, light brown flower with six petals. Below "Fedha" is the text "BY CHALLANI" in a smaller, dark teal sans-serif font.

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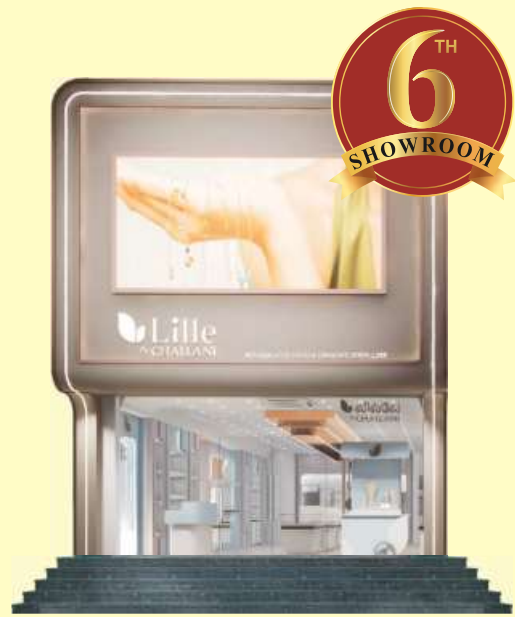


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Cultural frames (Clockwise from left) Mahesh Dattani; Shabana Azmi in a still from his film *Morning Raga*; and Jonathan Taikina Taylor. PHOTOS: SANDEEP SAXENA, THE HINDU ARCHIVES AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Narendra Kusnur

Playwright Mahesh Dattani, recipient of the Sahitya Akademi Award (1998), has played a pivotal role in shaping contemporary theatre in India. Since his debut with the 1988 satirical play, *Where There's A Will*, he has boldly explored themes such as religious fanaticism, homosexuality, child abuse and gender bias. His works include *Dance Like A Man*, *Tara*, *On a Muggy Night in Mumbai* and *Gauhar*. Mahesh has now teamed up with Brooklyn-based director Jonathan Taikina Taylor on the queer epic *The Monk & The Warrior*, be staged at Mumbai's Experimental Theatre from April 2 to 5. Featuring an international cast, the play begins with a "historically-accurate encounter between Alexander the Great and a Buddhist monk, which explodes into a love story that traverses

culture, space and time, weaving together queer histories across centuries and civilisations. "Though the inspiration comes from history, I still consider this play to be contemporary as the issue is still relevant. It talks about who we choose as our heroes. Often, the conqueror is seen as a hero, while the one choosing non-violence is perceived as a passive personality," says Mahesh. The idea for the play, he adds, came from Jonathan. "I got to know Jonathan through a friend, Akshay Gandhi, who had studied with him in New York. I also saw his production on Helen of Troy in New York and invited him to do a workshop, while he was in India. We kept in touch, and one day, he sent me a mail requesting me to write this play." Jonathan, the artistic director of The SuperGeographics, says he first thought of *The Monk & The Warrior* during a visit to

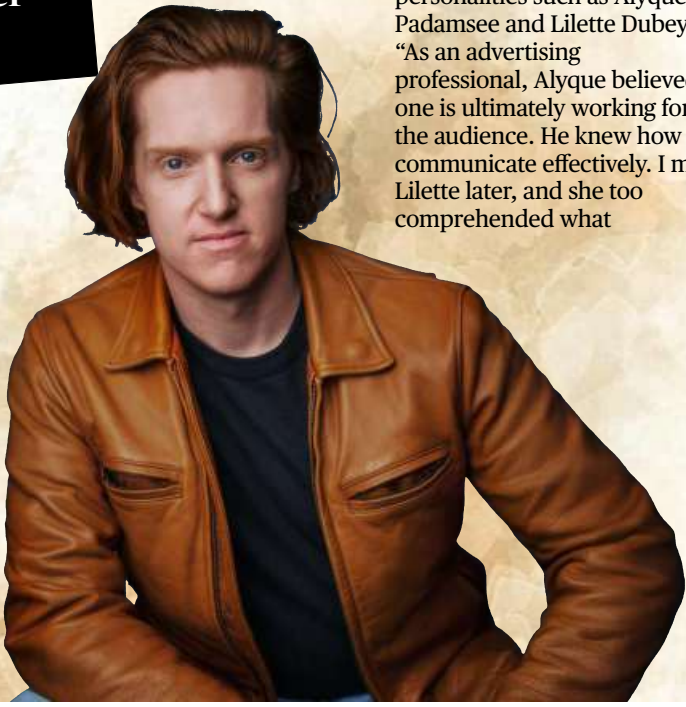
A window to the past

Mahesh Dattani's new play *The Monk & The Warrior* revisits queer stories across centuries

Nepal and India in 2019. "When I came to Bengaluru, I met people from the queer community. I thought I'd work on a play that looked at how queerness can be a counterpoint to the colonial mindset. Colonisation is all about going into a community and dictating how people should be. Queerness, in contrast, is about being within a community and allowing them to be themselves." Jonathan recalls reading a story about Alexander, said to be a famous Western queer, meeting a group of monks upon entering India. "His

relationship with a particular monk seemed to carry a romantic angle. One sought to conquer the world while the other longed for nothing." Through this play, Jonathan feels cultures can converge to uplift the voices and stories of people seldom heard. Mahesh shares, "For me, a queer is any person who creates his/her own system of living and loving. There's a misconception that queer stories are a Western concept, but in India, we have had such narratives in the Upapuranas, Upakathas and folk tales." On his approach to his subjects, Mahesh says, he

begins with research. "However, the research is just an inspiration, because as a fiction writer, I lean into my imagination to tell stories. While I try to use documented and authentic sources, it's also good to move beyond them as one risks ending up with a dry, factual story." Mahesh has also extensively worked with theatre personalities such as Alyque Padamsee and Lilette Dubey. "As an advertising professional, Alyque believed one is ultimately working for the audience. He knew how to communicate effectively. I met Lilette later, and she too comprehended what



resonated with the audience and what does not. Initially, I was self-indulgent, and reluctant to compromise. But as one grows, one learns that theatre works best as a collaboration, and the collaboration continues with your audience." Mahesh, who believes in the importance of feedback, says: "The first time we staged *Gauhar*, both Lilette and I realised that scriptwise, it was all over the place. So I made some edits, allowing the music to take over, as the character demanded it. With *Dance Like A Goddess*, which is a sequel to *Dance Like A Man*, I used a formal feedback process which I learnt from a European theatre company called Das. In other plays, I have used informal feedback methods." About *The Monk & The Warrior*, Mahesh shares though his earlier play *On A Muggy Night in Mumbai* was also about queer love, the two are very different. The former is more an interpersonal drama; while this one relies on poetry with the stories becoming metaphors for the journey." Among his plays, *Dance Like A Man* remains one of his most successful work; it was adapted to the screen by Pamela Rooks and went on to win a National Award. Mahesh wrote it to portray his experience as an aspiring male Bharatanatyam dancer, inspired by his gurus. In 2004, he wrote and directed the film *Morning Raga*, a story about how music unites different worlds. Asked whether he also thinks from a cinematic perspective while writing, Mahesh responds: "I believe that a play written with a film in mind is rather weak. I agree that some of my subjects have made good films, but then, most haven't. Theatre has its own charm, and requires a human touch that technology does not provide," says Mahesh.

CALENDAR

Award of Excellence

Kartik Fine Arts, will honour the following artistes on the occasion of its 51st anniversary to be held on April 14, 5.30 p.m., at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Mylapore.

Musicians Prema Ramamurthy and Trichur C. Narendran, theatre artistes Rajasekar and Prema Sadasivam will receive the Kartik Lifetime Achievement award. Vocalist Madurai T.N.S. Krishna, violinist L. Ramakrishnan, Kuchipudi artiste Sailaja, theatre artistes 'Kavithalaya' Krishnan, M. Jayakumar, S. Anand and Y.G. Madhuvanthi will be honoured with the Kartik Awards of Excellence. Akhila Srinivasan, director, Shriram Life Insurance Company, will be the chief guest, who will give away the awards. This will be followed by 'Jhankaar Live - R.P. Shravan and Band - A Cine Carnatic Confluence'.

Thematic concert

- **Sarvani Sangeetha Sabha Trust** will feature a thematic concert 'Sri Rama Kathamrutham' to be rendered by L. Samyuktha and L. Samhita, today at 6.15 p.m. The sisters will be accompanied by Nithyasree on the veena and K.K. Varun on the mridangam. Venue: Ragasudha Hall, Luz, Mylapore.
- **SHamsadhvani** annual cultural festival: Today, 6.10 p.m.: Prithvi Harish. April 4, 6.10 p.m.: K. Gayathri. April 5, 6.10 p.m.: Maharajapuram S. Ramachandran. Venue: Youth Hostel, Adyar.
- **SNarada Gana Sabha**, as part of Nadasangamam, will feature the following concerts at its mini hall. Details: April 8, 5.30 p.m.: Arvind Balaji and 7 p.m.: Gayatri Mani.

Tamil plays

Krishna Gana Sabha presents *Maathru Devo Bhava* on April 4, 7 p.m. Written and directed by Bombay Chanakya, and produced by JB Cultural Foundation, it will be staged at the Sabha premises, Maharajapuram Santhanam Salai, T. Nagar. The 16th show of **United Visual's Sangeetha Mumoorthigal** will be staged on April 5, 6.30 p.m. at Vani Mahal, T. Nagar.

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